

DRAFT - for review with mana whenua

ARCHITECTURE - DRAFT CULTURAL PRE-CHECK

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Te Aranga Design Audit - a pre-check against the seven principles

This audit reads the 12 May 2025 draft Resource Consent package against the seven public Te Aranga Maori Design Principles published by Auckland Council. Its job is to surface questions worth taking to TOA's cultural lead and to mana whenua. It is not a cultural determination - that work rests with mana whenua, with TOA, and with the project's cultural advisor. Te Aranga is referenced as a public framework; nothing in this report performs te reo or te ao Maori beyond what the framework itself names.

This is an AI-assisted preliminary audit by Assembl. It is a draft for review by the project architect, the practice's cultural lead, and mana whenua. It does not replace cultural review by mana whenua and cannot speak for iwi or hapu.

CULTURAL CONTEXT - WHAT THE SITE SITS WITHIN

- The site sits within the rohe of Ngati Whatua Orakei.
- The name Remuera carries whakapapa, often traced to Remu-wera; the Auckland isthmus carries names and ancestral trails of significance to mana whenua.
- Ohinerau (Mt Hobson) is a culturally significant maunga and former pa site within the wider visual landscape of the project.
- The Auckland Unitary Plan recognises cultural landscape values across Tamaki Makaurau; specific overlays (Sites of Significance, Sites of Value) should be confirmed against the parcel.
- Native species historically present in this part of the isthmus include kauri, totara, pohutukawa, kowhai, harakeke and karaka.

FINDINGS AGAINST THE SEVEN TE ARANGA PRINCIPLES

FLAG

Mana - Rangatiratanga / authority and partnership

The package contains no record of engagement with Ngati Whatua Orakei or any other iwi or hapu. For projects in this rohe, even small residential developments benefit from a recorded conversation with mana whenua, particularly where infrastructure (the 225 mm stormwater line) crosses or borders the site. The activity status under H4 does not require iwi engagement, but Te Aranga reads as a partnership framework, not a compliance one.

Te Aranga Maori Design Principles - Mana. Auckland Design Manual.

MISSING

Whakapapa - names and naming

Unit identifiers are administrative (16A, 16B, 16C, 16D). There is no acknowledgement of the whakapapa of the place name 'Remuera' or any te reo naming for the new units. Naming is a small but visible act of recognition; it is one of the easiest principles to honour at this stage.

Te Aranga Maori Design Principles - Whakapapa.

NOTE

Tohu - significant sites and external relationships

Ohinerau / Mt Hobson sits within the visual landscape of Remuera. The 8 m height envelope and roof profile of the new 16C and 16D units may sit below significant view shafts, but this should be confirmed. A site walk with mana whenua at the right stage answers this in minutes.

Te Aranga Maori Design Principles - Tohu. AUP D17 Historic Heritage / D18 Cultural Heritage overlays (confirm site-specific).

FLAG**Taiao - the natural environment**

The package shows 546.8 m² of landscaped area, which is well above the H4.6.10 minimum (40%). It does not show a planting plan. This is the highest-leverage gap: a landscape plan that names native species, references local ecology, and proposes a planting palette appropriate to the Auckland isthmus would shift this principle from a question to a strength.

Te Aranga Maori Design Principles - Taiao. AUP H4.6.10 Landscaped area.

FLAG**Mauri Tu - environmental health and water**

A 225 mm public stormwater line crosses or borders the site, and the proposal adds 295.9 m² of impervious area (within H4.6.8). The mauri of nearby waterways (the Tamaki / Orakei catchment) is a direct concern of Ngati Whatua Orakei. A stormwater design that prioritises permeable surfaces and on-site detention, named in cultural terms not just engineering ones, demonstrates this principle in practice.

Te Aranga Maori Design Principles - Mauri Tu. AUP E27 Transport / E36 Natural hazards / Auckland Council Stormwater Code of Practice.

MISSING**Mahi Toi - creative expression and narrative**

The elevations contain no visible cultural narrative, tohu or pukukoki - no carved or applied imagery, no kowhaiwhai or pattern, no glazing rhythm referencing local pukapuka. RC stage is early and this is a normal absence at this point. The principle invites the question: at developed-design stage, what narrative does the four-unit composition carry, and who tells it?

Te Aranga Maori Design Principles - Mahi Toi.

NOTE**Ahi Ka - living presence and ongoing occupation**

Retaining 16A and 16B and adding 16C and 16D increases density on a single title from two to four units. Density done well supports community presence; done poorly, it isolates. The arrival sequence, the visibility of the front door from the street, and the relationship between units are the moments where this principle is read.

Te Aranga Maori Design Principles - Ahi Ka.

QUESTIONS WORTH TAKING TO NGATI WHATUA ORAKEI

- Is the parcel within any Site of Significance or Site of Value overlay under the AUP that has not yet been picked up?
- Are there view shafts to Ohinerau or any other significant landmark that the proposed 16C and 16D massing should preserve or acknowledge?
- Are there ancestral place names appropriate for the project, the units, or the landscape elements?
- Are there native species Ngati Whatua Orakei would recommend for the planting plan, particularly along the stormwater corridor?
- Is there a way the cultural narrative could be carried through one specific design element - an entry threshold, a landscape feature, a piece of mahi toi - rather than spread thin across many?

RECOMMENDED NEXT STEPS

- Bring this draft to TOA's cultural lead before any conversation with mana whenua.
- Walk the site with mana whenua at concept-design or developed-design stage, not later. Their answers shape design; design cannot be retrofitted to their answers.
- Develop a planting plan with native species; treat it as a primary design deliverable, not an after-thought.
- Hold one design moment - a threshold, an entry, a landscape gesture - as the carrier of cultural narrative. Resist spreading the narrative thin.
- Document every cultural conversation in the project record. Auckland Council and any future audit will value the trail.

CLOSING

Te Aranga is a public framework; mana whenua are the authority on its application to a specific site. This audit can name questions worth asking; it cannot answer them. The right next step is a conversation, not a document. Assembl is working in English at this stage and will not perform te reo it has not earned through partnership with Te Hiku Media.